

Title: Scaling Community-Based Health Promotion: Insights From 20 Months of Cancer Screening and Prevention Outreach in BC

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Abstract:

Community-based health promotion remains a key strategy for increasing uptake of cancer screening and prevention services in British Columbia. While 92% of BC residents are interested in cancer screening and prevention, awareness gaps remain, particularly among women ages 18-34 for breast and cervical screening, and adults ages 50-70 for colon and lung screening. Research has shown that in-person community engagement can bridge these gaps through information sharing and fostering a sense of connection. Building on a successful pilot in 2024, BC Cancer's Prevention, Screening and Hereditary Cancer Program has scaled its community engagement program consisting of event-based booth activations and tailored community workshops. The program provides key information on breast, cervix, colon and lung screening, and prevention strategies addressing commercial tobacco use, alcohol consumption, sun safety, nutrition, radon and air pollution. Booth activations focus on broader outreach and public visibility, travelling to large-scale, high-traffic local events such as marathons, health expos, and the PNE fair, as well as trusted community hubs including libraries and food banks. Booths are staffed by BC Cancer's health promotion team and trained post-secondary co-op students. Activities feature an educational trivia wheel, translated resources, and call-to-action giveaways such as screening postcards and UV colour-changing stickers. Workshops offer a targeted, in-depth approach to engagement by collaborating with community partners to support specific sub-populations eligible for screening. The sessions leverage interactive presentations, on-site screening services and trusted co-facilitators. Wellness activities and supports to reduce logistical barriers like food and childcare are often offered, to meet communities where they are at and increase participation. Evaluation data is collected through post-event reporting, community partner feedback surveys and testimonials. As of September 2025, the program has brought the booth to 124 local events and facilitated approximately 27,331 meaningful interactions, with the public reporting increased screening and prevention awareness and appreciation of BC Cancer's presence in community settings. Since the program's launch of the workshop initiative, 75 workshops have been delivered alongside community health centers, newcomer, immigrant and refugee services, and cultural, faith-based, and equity-focused organizations. Over 100 screening mammograms and 210 cervix self-screening kits have been provided, often including first-time access by never-screeners. A notable program innovation has been the addition of the Sun Safety booth, offering timely, seasonal outreach aligned with skin cancer prevention goals. Screening workshop models also continue to evolve delivery formats, from standardized to co-designed approaches, to meet organizational capacity and acknowledge participant needs and cultural context. With increasing demand for adaptations, future programming will focus on building a community of practice, co-development, and continued integration of provincial screening services. By leveraging community strengths, the program aims to deepen its impact and support equitable access among those eligible for breast, cervix, colon and/or lung screening in British Columbia.

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